



No. 1 Jannik Sinner

When asked by *La Gazzetta dello Sport* what to expect from Sinner's return at the Italian Open, his close friend and compatriot Lorenzo Sonego replied, "An even stronger champion." That's bad news for the rest of the field — Sinner was already on a 21-match winning streak.

"He has a crazy desire to compete," added Sonego. "He can't wait to get back to what he loves — to feel the adrenaline of a match. He's very competitive." Although Sinner has won the last three Majors on hard courts, he's only reached the Roland Garros semifinals once — losing in five sets to eventual champion Alcaraz last year.

Despite taking the longest break of his career, Sinner impressed in early rounds of the Italian Open, beating an in-form Francisco Cerundolo 7-6(2), 6-3. He then overwhelmed Ruud 6-0, 6-1, winning 55 of the 77 points with a display of awesome power. "It's as near as

perfect that I witnessed," Ruud said. "It's just immensely impressive. ... It was like playing a wall that shoots 100 mph balls at you all the time." Although he stumbled in the final against Alcaraz, it would be unwise to dismiss the possibility of a first French Open title for the Italian.

Performing with an icy calm similar to that of Bjorn Borg, Sinner thrives on big games and points. He leads the ATP's Under Pressure Ratings at 259.5, and has won 80.6% of his tie-breaks. He also ranks No. 4 in service and No. 5 in return statistics. "The beauty of Sinner is that he hits with both depth and pace," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Jimmy Arias. Those attributes — plus his vastly improved defence — should propel him into the final. It will take a performance of the highest calibre to stop him.

No. 3 Carlos Alcaraz

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Top draw: Clay should pose challenges for the outrageously talented but occasionally erratic Carlos Alcaraz. AP

Alcaraz. It's the slowest surface and demands relentless consistency. In practice, however, this super athlete defies logical thinking. As Arias noted, "He wants to entertain the crowd, and it's sometimes to his own detriment." However, the Spanish phenom showed no signs of trouble in his final victory over Sinner at Indian Wells — 7-6(5), 6-1 — extending his head-to-head record against his arch-rival.

A year ago, Alcaraz came from two sets to one down to outlast Sinner in a hard-fought French Open semifinal thriller, 2-6, 6-3, 3-6, 6-4, 6-3, between the two wounded warriors. Alcaraz had a forearm injury that required him to wear a long sleeve, and Sinner had a lingering hip injury. After splitting the first two hard-hitting sets, both players suffered cramps in the third: